

Finally, a World Series for Baseball

Baseball has long called its championship the World Series although it only involves teams playing in the United States and Canada.

It started in 1903 when the Pittsburgh Pirates of the National League beat the Boston Americans of the American League for the championship. But the first official World Series, as it is known today, was in 1905 between the New York Giants and the Philadelphia Athletics.

Since then, the New York Yankees have won 27 World Series titles, more than any other team. This year, the Yankees will face the Los Angeles Dodgers for what sports fans believe will be a World Series seen around the world.

The competition is a best-of-seven-game championship. That means four wins in the series are needed to become the champion.

This year's series might have everything that sports fans could want. It is a competition between teams from the two largest cities in the U.S. It is a competition between the two best teams in baseball. And the contest involves two of the biggest baseball stars, Shohei Ohtani of Japan and Aaron Judge of the U.S.

New York Yankees' Aaron Judge runs the bases after hitting a two-run home against the Cleveland Guardians during the eighth inning in Game 3 of the baseball AL Championship Series Thursday, Oct. 17, 2024, in Cleveland. (AP Photo/Jeff Roberson)

Both players have already won the Most Valuable Player Award or MVP, given to the best player in the National League and the American League. Ohtani has won it twice and Judge once. The two are likely to be named MVP in each league again this year.

Ohtani joined the Dodgers earlier this year with a record 10-year contract valued at \$700 million. After receiving the largest contract ever in team sports history, Ohtani hit 54 home runs, stole 59 bases, and led the National League in almost all offensive numbers.

Talking to reporters on Tuesday, October 22, Judge called Ohtani “the best player in the game.” He added that Ohtani “hits for average, he hits for power, the speed.”

But Judge himself holds the American League record with 62 home runs in 2022. This year, he leads all of baseball, hitting 58 home runs. And he also leads all of baseball, both American and National Leagues, in offensive numbers, including 144 RBIs, 133 walks, on-base percentage, and slugging percentage.

As expected, Ohtani led the Dodgers to the best record in the National League, and Judge captained the Yankees to the best record in the American League. The two best players, though, have a lot of help.

The Dodgers have two former MVPs, Mookie Betts and Freddie Freeman, in the lineup. The Yankees have just one former MVP in Giancarlo Stanton. But they also have Juan Soto of the Dominican Republic, who is often called a “generational talent” in the game.

Customers shop for goods related to Shohei Ohtani of the Los Angeles Dodgers at a sporting goods store, "SELECTION," in Shinjuku district Wednesday, Oct. 23, 2024 in Tokyo. (AP Photo/Eugene Hoshiko)

The first game of the 2024 World Series will start on Friday, October 25. The games are sold out meaning all tickets have been sold. But, for those who still want to watch the game in person, it is possible to pay more than \$1,000 for a seat or up to \$10,000 for the best seats in the reselling market StubHub.

Others can watch the television broadcast that is expected to set a record for people watching in Ohtani’s home country of Japan.

After the Dodgers beat the New York Mets to get to the World Series, Ohtani told reporters, “The goal was to get this far.”

As for Judge, “getting a chance to play on the biggest stage and in the biggest moment, I think that’s going to be pretty cool to watch,” he said.

I’m Mario Ritter, Jr.

Hai Do wrote this report for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

home run - n. การตีลูกเบสบอลให้พ้นสนามและได้คะแนนทันที

stolen bases - n. การขโมยเบส (การที่ผู้เล่นวิ่งไปยังเบสถัดไปโดยที่ไม่มีใครตีลูก)

RBI (runs batted in) - n. คะแนนที่ผู้เล่นทำได้หรือทำให้เพื่อนร่วมทีมทำได้

walk - n. การได้เดินไปเบสแรกโดยไม่ต้องตีลูก (เมื่อได้ลูกบอล 4 ลูก)

slugging percentage - n. เปอร์เซนต์สลักกิ้ง (การวัดคุณภาพการตีลูกของผู้เล่น)

lineup - n. รายชื่อผู้เล่นตัวจริง

talent - n. ผู้เล่นที่มีความสามารถ/พรสวรรค์

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What is the geographical scope of the teams participating in the World Series, as mentioned in the article?

Teams from North America only

Teams from the United States and Canada

Teams from countries around the world

Teams primarily from the United States with some international players

2. When did the *first recorded championship* involving the World Series take place, according to the text?

1905

1903

2024

The text does not specify

3. Which teams competed in the *first official* World Series as it is known today?

Pittsburgh Pirates and Boston Americans

New York Yankees and Los Angeles Dodgers

New York Giants and Philadelphia Athletics

Cleveland Guardians and New York Yankees

4. Which team holds the record for the most World Series titles?

Boston Americans

Los Angeles Dodgers

New York Giants

New York Yankees

5. Who are the two teams expected to compete in this year's World Series?

New York Yankees and Los Angeles Dodgers

Pittsburgh Pirates and Boston Americans

New York Giants and Philadelphia Athletics

Cleveland Guardians and New York Yankees

6. How many wins are necessary to become the champion in a best-of-seven-game World Series?

Two wins

Three wins

Four wins

Seven wins

7. According to the article, what is one key reason this year's World Series is anticipated to be particularly exciting for sports fans?

It features teams from the smallest cities in the U.S.

It is a competition between the two lowest-ranked teams in baseball.

It involves two of the biggest baseball stars, Shohei Ohtani and Aaron Judge.

It is the first time these two teams have ever met in the World Series.

8. How many Most Valuable Player (MVP) awards has Shohei Ohtani won before this year's potential award?

Once

Twice

Three times

The text does not specify

9. What made Shohei Ohtani's contract with the Dodgers noteworthy earlier this year?

It was a short-term contract worth \$700 million.

It was the largest contract ever in team sports history.

It was the first time a Japanese player signed with the Dodgers.

He broke the home run record immediately after signing it.

10. After joining the Dodgers, in which league did Shohei Ohtani lead in almost all offensive numbers?

American League

National League

Japanese League

Minor League

11. How did Aaron Judge characterize Shohei Ohtani when talking to reporters?

As a good teammate

As a strong hitter but slow runner

As the best player in the game

As an overrated player

12. What American League record does Aaron Judge currently hold, set in 2022?

Most stolen bases in a season

Most RBIs in a single game

Most home runs in a season

Highest slugging percentage

13. According to the article, in addition to leading in home runs this year, what other offensive categories does Aaron Judge lead all of baseball in?

Only stolen bases

RBIs, walks, on-base percentage, and slugging percentage

Only batting average

Only hits and runs scored

14. What was the primary achievement of both Shohei Ohtani and Aaron Judge regarding their teams' regular season records?

They led their teams to second place in their respective leagues.

Ohtani led the Dodgers to the best record in the National League, and Judge captained the Yankees to the best record in the American League.

They both led their teams to win the World Series.

They both set individual records for most games played.

15. Besides Giancarlo Stanton, who is referred to as a "generational talent" on the Yankees' team?

Mookie Betts

Freddie Freeman

Juan Soto

Shohei Ohtani